Every term has a mid-term break where cadets can either take part in some organized activity, such as a bike hike or go home to their parents or local guardians. In either case, written signed permission has to be obtained. Many of the cadets obtained this consent by signing it themselves or signing off for each other. This kind of fudging was frowned upon, more from the safety and security point of view, should some untoward incident occur. Since the consents usually came by post, the sheet would be creased along the folds, which was taken as an indicator of its genuineness. In my fifth term, I also applied for permission to go home during the mid-term break and submitted the parental consent. The Divisional Officer (DivO), a Navy Lieutenant, thought it was a forged consent and wanted me to own up, which in itself would have made me liable for disciplinary action. I steadfastly refused to admit to any wrongdoing. I was marched up to the Squadron Commander, Wing Commander PB Jadhav, where the DivO played his trump card. This is a forged consent, he said, because it does not have any folds or creases. I readily admitted to that, elaborating that I was a local, that my father had come to visit me the previous Sunday, the consent was indeed written in my hand, which my father had signed. The fact that my father had visited could easily be verified through the guest register, I added helpfully, not realizing that the DivO was most upset at being exposed. The Squadron Commander appeared sympathetic, but I guess he did not want the DivO to be let down, so the net result was that I was quite unjustly awarded fourteen days' restrictions.

Restrictions (as every officer knows) are a form of punishment involving extra drill in the daytime, an endurance run of 10-odd km in the afternoon and reporting at specified times during the day outside the Sudan Block, the main Administrative Block, much like a parolee reporting to the police station. This would

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